AGES 3–4 · FREE · NO SIGN-UP

Learn Through Play: preschool activities for ages 3 to 4.

Early sounds, counting, shapes and patterns, with a short game and a real-world version of every activity. Free, with no sign-up.

For grown-ups

Play together where you can. Talking about what your child chose and why is where much of the learning happens.

Hints come before answers. After three tries the answer is shown kindly, with no penalty.

Little and often works: a few minutes, then something hands-on.

Children develop at different rates. These are ideas to enjoy, not a test.

9 ACTIVITIES

Things to do together

Each one has a clear purpose, a way to play, and words to use.

PHONOLOGICAL AWARENESS

Listen for the sound

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Hear the first sound in a word, starting with /s/.

You need

- A few objects: sock, spoon, cup, ball

How to play

1. Play the listening game with sound on.
2. Hold up objects and say each name, stretching the first sound: "sssock".
3. Ask which ones start with /s/.

Things to say

"Sssun. Do you hear the snake sound?"

"Does cup start with /s/?"

"Can you think of another /s/ word?"

Take it further

Play I Spy with sounds: "I spy something that starts with /b/."

RHYMING

Which one rhymes?

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Hear when two words end with the same sound.

You need

- Nursery rhyme book

How to play

1. Play the rhyming game together.
2. Read a rhyme and pause before the rhyming word.
3. Make silly rhymes for family names.

Things to say

"Cat, hat. They sound the same at the end!"

"Does dog rhyme with log?"

"What rhymes with bear?"

Take it further

Make up a two-line rhyme about Red Teddy.

COUNTING

Count to five

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 2 min

What it builds: Count up to five objects and know the last number says how many.

You need

- Five small toys

How to play

1. Play the counting game together.
2. Set out five toys and count them, touching each.
3. Mix them up and count again. Still five!

Things to say

"How many are there?"

"We moved them. Are there still five?"

"Show me three fingers."

Take it further

Count out five crackers at snack time.

NUMBERS

Match the number to the group

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Link a written numeral to a group of that many objects.

You need

- Sticky notes with 1–5 written on them
- Small toys

How to play

1. Play the matching game together.
2. Put a sticky note on the table and build a group of that many toys.
3. Swap: your child builds a group and you find its number.

Things to say

"This says three. Can you make three?"

"Which number matches?"

"Let's count to check."

Take it further

Spot numbers on doors, buses and clocks.

PATTERNS

Finish the pattern

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: See what repeats and continue a simple AB pattern.

You need

- Two colors of blocks, or forks and spoons

How to play

1. Play the pattern game together.
2. Make red, blue, red, blue with blocks and ask what comes next.
3. Clap and stomp a pattern: clap, stomp, clap, stomp.

Things to say

"Red, blue, red, blue… what's next?"

"What keeps happening again?"

"Can you make a pattern for me?"

Take it further

Thread a bead necklace in a pattern.

MEMORY

Color pairs

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 3 min

What it builds: Hold where things are in mind and find matching pairs.

You need

- A tray and five household objects
- A tea towel

How to play

1. Play the color pairs game together.
2. Put five objects on a tray, cover them and remove one.
3. Ask which one is missing.

Things to say

"Where was the other green one?"

"What's missing?"

"How did you remember?"

Take it further

Make it six objects when five is easy.

SHAPES

Name the shape

On-screen game + off-screen play · About 2 min

What it builds: Name circles, squares, triangles and rectangles.

You need

- Paper, crayons, scissors (grown-up cuts)

How to play

1. Play the shapes game together.
2. Draw shapes and talk about sides and corners.
3. Make a picture out of cut-out shapes: a house, a rocket.

Things to say

"How many corners does it have?"

"Is a door a square or a rectangle?"

"What can we make with triangles?"

Take it further

Hunt for rectangles around the house.

SEQUENCING AND STORIES

First, next, last

Off-screen · About 10 min

What it builds: Retell events in order using first, next and last.

You need

- A familiar picture book

How to play

1. After reading, ask what happened first.
2. Ask what happened next, then at the end.
3. Use everyday routines too: getting dressed, making toast.

Things to say

"What happened first?"

"And then?"

"How did it end?"

Take it further

Draw three pictures of a story and put them in order.

CURIOSITY AND PROBLEM-SOLVING

Sink or float?

Off-screen · About 15 min

What it builds: Make a guess, test it and talk about what happened.

You need

- A bowl of water
- Spoon, cork, leaf, coin, toy boat (supervise closely)

How to play

1. Hold up each object and ask: will it sink or float?
2. Drop it in and watch.
3. Sort objects into a sink pile and a float pile.

Things to say

“What do you think will happen?”

“Were you right?”

“Why do you think it floated?”

Take it further

Try to make a floating thing sink by adding coins.

> These activities relate to the Head Start Early Learning Outcomes Framework domains of Literacy, Mathematics Development, Scientific Reasoning and Approaches to Learning. That is our own mapping, not an official review or endorsement.